The More Excellent Way

1 Corinthians 13:1-13 (KJV)

Scripture

1 Corinthians 13:1-13

[1] Though I speak with the tongues of men and of angels, and have not charity, I am become as sounding brass, or a tinkling cymbal. [2] And though I have the gift of prophecy, and understand all mysteries, and all knowledge; and though I have all faith, so that I could remove mountains, and have not charity, I am nothing. [3] And though I bestow all my goods to feed the poor, and though I give my body to be burned, and have not charity, it profiteth me nothing. [4] Charity suffereth long, and is kind; charity envieth not; charity vaunteth not itself, is not puffed up, [5] Doth not behave itself unseemly, seeketh not her own, is not easily provoked, thinketh no evil; [6] Rejoiceth not in iniquity, but rejoiceth in the truth; [7] Beareth all things, believeth all things, hopeth all things, endureth all things. [8] Charity never faileth: but whether there be prophecies, they shall fail; whether there be tongues, they shall cease; whether there be knowledge, it shall vanish away. [9] For we know in part, and we prophesy in part. [10] But when that which is perfect is come, then that which is in part shall be done away. [11] When I was a child, I spake as a child, I understood as a child, I thought as a child: but when I became a man, I put away childish things. [12] For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known. [13] And now abideth faith, hope, charity, these three; but the greatest of these is charity.

Outline

1. Without love, nothing else counts

Without love, I am as sounding brass or a tinkling _____.

Without love, even great gifts profit me _____.

Read: 1 Corinthians 13:1-3; Matthew 22:37-40; 1 John 4:7-8

2. Love is shown in how we treat people

Love suffers long and is _____.

Love is seen in how we _____ other people.

Read: 1 Corinthians 13:4-7; Romans 12:9-10; Colossians 3:12-14

3. Love never fails

Charity never _____.

The greatest of faith, hope and charity is _____.

Read: 1 Corinthians 13:8-13; 1 John 4:16; Romans 8:38-39

Discussion questions

1. Why do you think Paul put this chapter in the middle of a discussion about spiritual gifts?

2. Read verses 4-7 with your own name in place of "charity." Which line is hardest to say truthfully?

3. Love "thinketh no evil" (v. 5) and keeps no record of wrongs. How is that different from ignoring wrongdoing?

4. Why is love greater than faith and hope?

This week

Choose one line from verses 4-7 that you most need. Write it on a card and carry it with you. Each evening this week, ask: "Where did I practice this today, and where did I fail?" Then thank God for his love that never fails you.